THE MOST VALUABLE AI SKILL IS SAYING NO

THE DECK AND THE CODE
github.com/hughes-research/nolaai-2026

Screening AI use cases for real return.

DUSTIN T HUGHES · VP of Technology, Laborde Products

NOAI 2026 · Friday, Nov 13, 2026 · 2:30–4:00 PM · Education Center, New Orleans Jazz Museum

EXERCISE 1 · 10 MINUTES

INVENTORY TWO WEEKS OF REAL WORK.

1 What did you do more than twice?	2 What did you copy from one place to another?	3 What did you wait on?	4 What did you dread?

	TASK	HOW OFTEN	MINUTES EACH TIME	WHO DOES IT
01				
02				
03				
04				
05				
06				
07				
08				
09				
10				
11				
12				

EXERCISE 2 · 5 MINUTES

PICK THREE.

Circle three in your list, then name them here.

A One you'd love to pitch

B One that's boring

C One you'd be embarrassed to bring up

TURN OVER · EXERCISE 3 →

EXERCISE 3 · 10 MINUTES

RUN YOUR THREE THROUGH THE GATES.

Start with the minutes, then take the gates in order. Stop at the first NO.

ONE COLUMN EACH A number on a dashed line is a default. Cross it out and write your own.	EXAMPLE Invoice follow-up reminders	A One you'd love to pitch	B One that's boring	C One you'd be embarrassed to bring up

START HERE THE MINUTES *Minutes are the raw material. Money is what they turn into.*

Minutes saved × times a week	*6 × 60*	MIN	TIMES	MIN	TIMES	MIN	TIMES
= minutes a week × $25 = return At $30 an hour, 50 weeks. At $60 an hour: $50.	*$9,000* *360 × $25*	MIN A WEEK	A YEAR $	MIN A WEEK	A YEAR $	MIN A WEEK	A YEAR $
Service business: is this larger? Minutes a week ÷ 1.2 = hours a year. × share that is paid work × $ margin an hour.	—	HOURS	IF LARGER $	HOURS	IF LARGER $	HOURS	IF LARGER $

☐ GATE 1 COST *What does it cost to run?*

HOUSE RULE NO when yearly cost is more than 30% of yearly return.

What runs it? Price of 1,000 runs:*	Spreadsheet or plain code **about $0** Small model **$0.45** Frontier model **$36**						
To run it for a year Times a week × 50 ÷ 1,000 × the price.	*$1.35* *3,000 runs* *3 × $0.45*	PRICE $	A YEAR $	PRICE $	A YEAR $	PRICE $	A YEAR $
+ tools = cost a year Tools, dollars a month × 12, plus the line above.	*$1.35* *$1.35 + $0*	TOOLS $	COST $	TOOLS $	COST $	TOOLS $	COST $
Cost test: 30% of return Cost a year bigger than this? NO.	*$2,700* *$1.35 is less*	$		$		$	

☐ GATE 2 RETURN *What comes back: cash sooner, or more work done?*

HOUSE RULE NO when yearly return is under $5,000 and it takes no days off the cash cycle.

On the cash path? Days faster? quote → order → pick → ship → invoice → collect. A tick is not enough: only the days count.	*yes* *2 days faster*	☐ YES	DAYS FASTER	☐ YES	DAYS FASTER	☐ YES	DAYS FASTER

☐ GATE 3 EFFORT *What does it take to build it and keep it alive?*

HOUSE RULE NO when payback is longer than 26 weeks.

Build and rollout hours × $75 The one-time cost.	*$2,250* *30 × $75*	HOURS $		HOURS $		HOURS $	
Upkeep hours a month × $900 12 months at $75 an hour: upkeep for a year.	*$1,350* *1.5 × $900*	HOURS $		HOURS $		HOURS $	
= left over a year Return − cost − upkeep. None left: NO.	*$7,649*	$		$		$	
Payback test: half of left over One-time cost bigger than this? NO. In weeks: one-time cost × 52 ÷ left over.	*$3,824* *$2,250 is less*	$		$		$	

☐ GATE 4 POTENTIAL *If it works, how far does it grow?*

HOUSE RULE NO when growth is below 1× or nobody owns the freed time.

How many times bigger in a year? 1 = the same size · 1.5 = half again · 2 = double	*1.5×*	TIMES BIGGER		TIMES BIGGER		TIMES BIGGER	
Who owns the freed time? A named person who decides what it becomes.	*named*	A NAME		A NAME		A NAME	
VERDICT **1** Cost · **2** Return · **3** Effort · **4** Potential. Circle PASS or NO at each gate. After a NO, stop.	☐☐☐☐ *passes all four*	1 2 3 4 PASS PASS PASS PASS NO NO NO NO		1 2 3 4 PASS PASS PASS PASS NO NO NO NO		1 2 3 4 PASS PASS PASS PASS NO NO NO NO	
Two-year value If more than one passed: (return − cost) × (1 + times bigger) − one-time − 2 × upkeep.	*$17,547*	TWO YEARS $		TWO YEARS $		TWO YEARS $	

THE MATH PICKS

THE HIGHEST TWO-YEAR VALUE: ITS LETTER AND NAME

* List prices, for runs of 2,000 tokens in and 500 out each (about a page and a half read, a few paragraphs written). Small model: Claude Haiku 5.5. Frontier model: Claude Fable 5.2. Source: BenchLM leaderboard export, November 2026. The example column is made up, to show the sums.

THE LADDER OF TOOLS *Climb only as far as the task makes you.*

Don't automate · Spreadsheet formula · Plain code · Small model · Frontier model · Agent

THE WAYPOINT STANDARD

A win only counts with the task, the prompt, the output, and the time saved.